

Your LinkedIn cheat sheet

Everything from today's talk, plus the parts we didn't have time for. Start with the three things on the right — those are the ones that matter today.

Do these three things today

1 Connect in the room

Pull out your phone during the conversation. "Can I find you on LinkedIn real quick?" is a completely normal thing to say at an event like this.

2 Always add a note

Never send a blank request. One specific sentence about what you actually talked about is what makes you findable three months from now.

3 Follow up within 48 hours

One short message while they still remember your face. Reference the conversation, ask one small question. Don't attach a resume and don't ask for a job.

Set up a profile worth looking at

Alumni *will* look you up after today. Your profile's job is to survive a recruiter keyword search and back up a referral — not to replace your GitHub.

- **Headline.** Not "Student at BYU." This is the most heavily weighted field in recruiter search, so use it: *CS student at BYU | Backend & distributed systems | Seeking Summer 2027 SWE internship*
- **Photo.** Plain background, good light, shoulders up, you smiling. A decent phone photo is fine. No photo is not.
- **Banner image.** Swap the default grey for anything — campus, a skyline, a simple color. Takes 30 seconds and instantly looks more deliberate.
- **About.** Three or four sentences, first person. What you study, what you're drawn to, what you're looking for. Not a resume summary.
- **Experience.** Retail, campus jobs, and club roles all count. Write what you accomplished, not what you were assigned. Numbers help.
- **Skills.** Search filters, not decoration. List the actual technologies — Python, React, Go, PostgreSQL — not "programming." Recruiters filter on exact terms.
- **Featured section.** Sits near the top and almost no student uses it. Your GitHub, personal site, or a project demo goes here — for CS it's the most valuable field on the page after your headline.
- **Custom URL.** Two minutes to change, and it's what goes on your resume instead of a string of random digits.

Settings most students never find

- **Turn off activity broadcasts before you edit.** Otherwise every tweak notifies your whole network. Settings → Visibility → Share profile updates with your network. Turn it back on when you're done.
- **Private browsing mode.** You can view profiles anonymously — useful when you're researching an interviewer. Trade-off: while private, you lose your own "who viewed your profile" data.
- **"Open to Work" has two versions.** Recruiters-only (discreet) or the green photo frame (public). Most people don't know the discreet option exists — it matters if you're currently employed.
- **Job alerts.** Save a search once and let LinkedIn email you new postings daily instead of checking manually.

Keep going on page 2: finding BYU alumni, message templates, and using LinkedIn for the actual job search.

Finding BYU alumni who do what you want to do

This is the single most useful feature on LinkedIn for a student, and almost nobody knows it's there.

- Search **Brigham Young University** and open the **school page** — not a person, the university's own page.
- Click the **Alumni** tab (on mobile it may be labeled **People**).
- Now filter. You can narrow by **where they live**, **where they work**, **what they do**, **what they studied**, and **what they're skilled at**.
- Filter **what they do** to **Engineering** and **where they work** to a company you want. You'll almost always find BYU CS grads there — and a shared school is a legitimate reason to reach out cold.
- Sort by graduation year to find people three to five years ahead of you. They remember what recruiting was like and they're far more likely to reply than a senior executive.

Messages you can copy

Short, specific, no ask in the first message. That gets replies; everything else gets ignored.

CONNECTION NOTE — SOMEONE YOU MET TODAY

"Great talking with you about what code review actually looks like on your team today — thanks for the advice on summer internships. Glad we connected."

COLD OUTREACH — ALUMNI AT A COMPANY YOU WANT

"Hi [Name], I'm a junior in CS at BYU. I found you through the BYU alumni page and saw you're a [role] at [company] — that's the kind of work I'm aiming for. Would you be open to 15 minutes to hear how you got there? Happy to work around your schedule."

FOLLOWING UP AFTER A CONVERSATION

"Hi [Name], thanks again for the time last week — the point about going deep on one project instead of shipping five shallow ones really changed what I'm building next. I started [project] because of it. I'll keep you posted."

MESSAGING A RECRUITER ABOUT A SPECIFIC ROLE

"Hi [Name], I applied for the [exact job title] role (req #[number]) last week. I'm a [year] in CS at BYU, and [one specific reason you fit] — something you shipped, relevant coursework, a past internship]. Happy to send my GitHub over if that's useful."

Using LinkedIn for the actual job search

- **Recruiting starts absurdly early.** Postings for next summer's SWE internships often open in August and September. A profile that's ready in the fall beats a perfect one in March.
- **Referrals are the whole game.** A referral from someone inside is what gets a human to actually open your application. That is what the alumni search on this page is for.
- **Apply in the first few days.** Postings collect hundreds of applicants fast, and many are reviewed roughly in the order they arrive.
- **Skip Premium for now.** The free tier does everything on this sheet. Save it for when you're actively interviewing and want InMail.

If you only do one thing: connect with the people you talked to today, with a note, before the day is over. The rest of this sheet still works next week — that part doesn't.